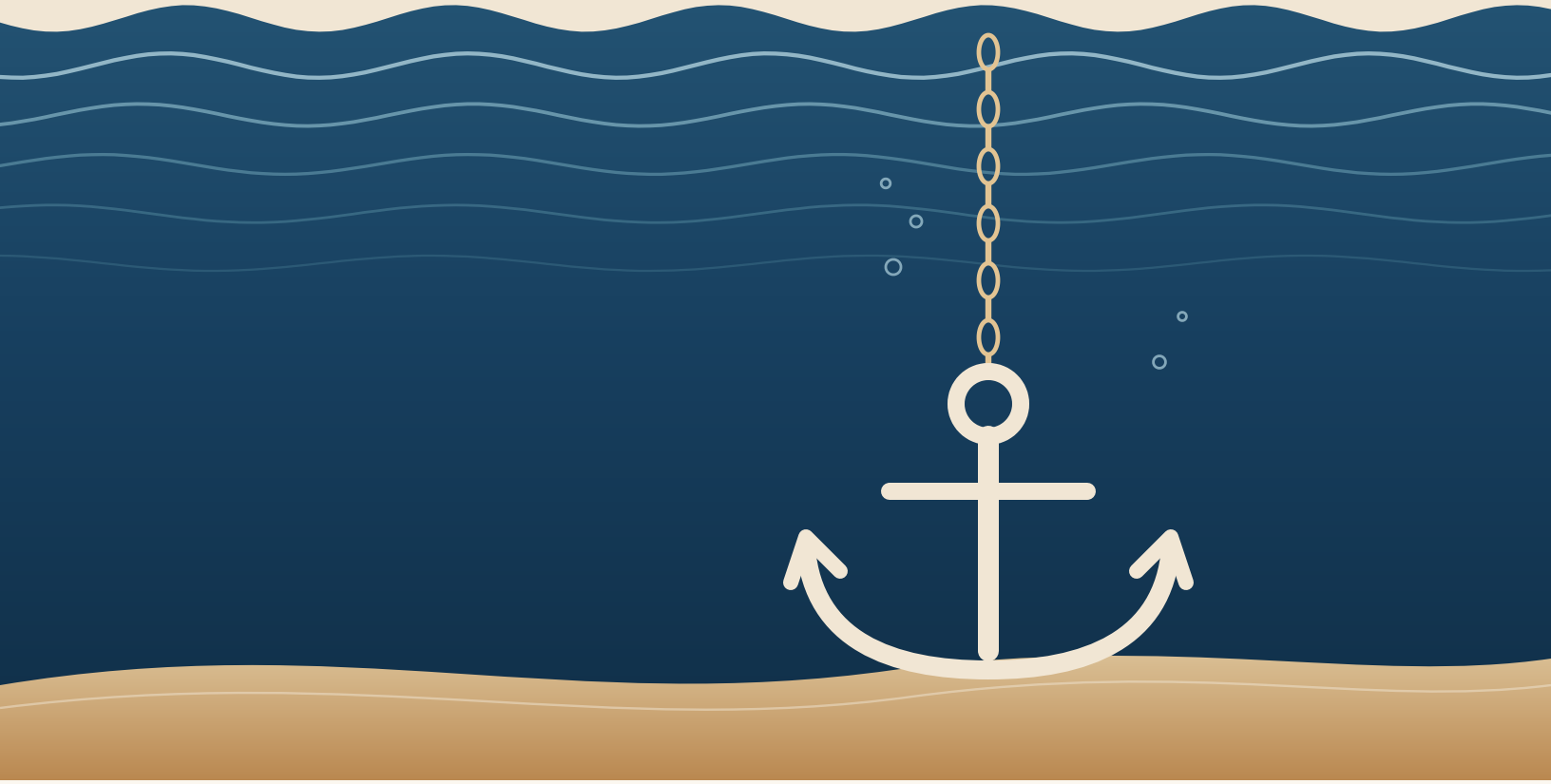
ANCHORED PARENTING SERIES · BOOK 1



A PARENT WORKBOOK

Six Anchors

Understanding and guiding everyday behavior with calm confidence

A practical workbook for parents and caregivers on why children behave the way they do, how to build connection, and what to do in the moments that matter most, with scripts, worksheets and a personal parenting plan.

BEHAVIOR | CONNECTION | ROUTINES | BIG FEELINGS

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Independent resource in original language, informed by the principles of applied behavior analysis and the online course *Practical Parenting: No Fluff, Just Results* (@ABAnaturally). Not affiliated with or endorsed by the course author. For educational use; not a substitute for individualized professional guidance.

ANCHORED INSIDE
COUNSELING SERVICES

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ABOUT THE SERIES

The Anchored Parenting Series

Each book in the series takes one part of family life and turns it into steady, practical tools you can use at home. Book 1, *Six Anchors*, lays the foundation: how behavior works and the six anchors every later book builds on.

01

START HERE

Welcome

Parenting doesn't come with a manual, and the hardest moments rarely happen when we're rested and ready. This workbook gives you a steady place to come back to: a handful of clear principles, words you can use in the moment, and small practices that add up over time.

The ideas here come from the science of how behavior is learned, translated into everyday family life. You won't find a perfect-parent standard. You'll find tools that help you stay calm, stay connected, and help your child learn what to do instead.

> **Children do well when they can. When they can't, our job is to understand why, teach what's missing, and stay steady while they learn.**

The six anchors

1
Understand

Behavior is communication. Look for the need underneath it.

What is my child trying to get or avoid?

2
Connect

Attention is your most powerful tool. Give it freely to what you want to grow.

Have I filled my child's cup today?

3
Clarify

Tell and show exactly what to do before the hard moment.

Does my child know what is expected?

4
Teach

Replace problem behavior with an easier way to meet the same need.

What could my child do instead?

5
Follow Through

Say it once, calmly, and help them do it.

Am I following through every time?

6
Stay Steady

Your calm is the safest place for big feelings.

A lesson, or a steady presence?

KEY IDEA

How to use this workbook

- Read one anchor at a time. Each section is short on purpose.
- Pick **one** practice to try for a week or two before adding another.
- Use the reflection prompts to notice patterns in your own family.
- Turn to the Everyday Situations guide when a specific challenge comes up.
- Fill in your Anchored Parenting Plan at the end and revisit it every few weeks.

KEY IDEA

A note on progress

Change takes time for children and for adults. Expect some bumpy days, and expect behavior to sometimes get louder before it gets better when old patterns stop working. Progress, not perfection, is the goal.

ANCHOR 1

02 Understand the Behavior

Every behavior makes sense once we know what it's for. Before we respond, we get curious.

Behavior is communication

Behavior is anything a child says or does: asking, whining, hitting, sharing, slamming a door. Most behavior is **learned**. When a behavior works (it gets a child something they want or gets them out of something they don't), it becomes more likely to happen again.

That means a behavior that keeps happening is getting *something* out of the situation, even if what it gets is a lecture, a delay, or a parent who finally gives in.

The ABCs

Every behavior sits between what happened right before and what happened right after.

A: What happened right before	B: What my child did	C: What happened right after
Told it's time to turn off the tablet	Screamed and threw the tablet	Got five more minutes
Parent on a phone call	Climbed on the counter	Parent hung up and came over
Asked to put shoes on	Put shoes on	"Thank you! You're ready to go."
Sibling took a toy	Asked, "Can I have it back?"	Got the toy back

The same behavior can mean very different things. A child who hits during a game of tag and a child who hits when it's time for bed need very different responses. You can't choose a response from the behavior alone.

The four reasons behind behavior

Function	My child is trying to...	Common examples
Attention	Get a reaction from someone, positive or negative	Silly noises at dinner, poking a sibling, "Watch me!"
Access	Get an item or activity	Grabbing a toy, whining for a snack, more screen time
Escape	Get out of a task, demand or situation	Stalling at bedtime, melting down at clean-up
Sensory	Get a feeling that is rewarding on its own	Humming, spinning, chewing; happens even when alone

Setting events: the "why today?" factor

Some days the same request goes smoothly and other days it falls apart. Tiredness, hunger, illness, a hard day at school, too much noise, or too little one-on-one time don't cause behavior, but they lower a child's tolerance. On those days, lighten demands, add support, and give extra connection.

Track it before you change it

Write down a few hard moments over three days. Patterns that feel random often turn out to be predictable.

WORKSHEET

Behavior detective log

Day/time	Right before (A)	What my child did (B)	Right after (C)	Likely reason

My best guess: When _____, my child _____, and it usually leads to _____.

PAUSE AND REFLECT

Which behavior frustrates me most right now? What might it be getting my child?

What setting events (sleep, hunger, transitions) make hard moments more likely in our home?

ANCHOR 2

03 Connect First

Attention is the most powerful thing a parent has. Spend it generously on the behavior you want to see more of.

Fill the cup

Children are wired to seek our attention, and they will take it however they can get it. When a child's cup is full of warm, positive attention, they have far less reason to seek it through misbehavior.

The trap most of us fall into: we barely notice when things go smoothly, and we respond quickly and intensely when they don't. Without meaning to, we teach that misbehavior is the fastest way to get us.

KEY IDEA

Aim for five to one

Try for **five positive interactions for every correction**. Positive interactions can be tiny: a smile, a thank-you, a comment on something they're building, a quick hug.

Notice the ordinary

The behaviors that make family life run smoothly are easy to overlook. Catch them out loud:

- Coming to the table the first time you call
- Turning off a show when asked
- Playing quietly while you're on the phone
- Being gentle with a sibling or pet
- Waiting patiently, sharing, or cleaning up without being asked
- Handling a disappointment calmly

Praise that works

Instead of	Try
"Good job."	"You hung your coat on the hook without me asking. That's so helpful."
"You're so smart!"	"You kept trying even when that puzzle was tricky."
"Nice." (much later)	Praise within a few seconds of the behavior
The same phrase every time	Vary your words; sometimes just describe what they did

Praise more often while a new skill is being learned, and give extra for things that take real effort.

Daily connection

- **Special time:** 10 minutes a day of play your child leads. No phones, no teaching, no quizzing.
- **Micro-moments:** two or three short bursts of undivided attention during routines you already have, like car rides, bath time, or snack.
- **Narrate instead of question:** "You're building the tallest tower!" invites connection; "What color is that?" feels like a test.
- **Talk about what they love,** just to connect, not to teach.

Be slow to react to small stuff

Many annoying behaviors (silly talk, whining, minor bickering) fade quickly when they don't get a big reaction. Stay neutral and busy, then give warm attention the moment the behavior stops.

TRY IT THIS WEEK

- [ ] Count my positives and corrections for one afternoon
- [ ] Ten minutes of special time every day
- [ ] Name three ordinary good behaviors each day
- [ ] Put a "5 to 1" reminder on the fridge

PAUSE AND REFLECT

What does my child do well that I usually take for granted?

When does my child get my most focused attention: when things go well, or when they go wrong?

ANCHOR 3

04 Be Clear and Set Them Up to Succeed

Children can't meet an expectation they don't understand. Teach it before you need it.

Don't assume they know

Much of what looks like defiance is really confusion. "Be good," "clean up," and "get ready" can mean many things to a child. Before deciding a child won't do something, check whether they know exactly what to do and have practiced it.

Make expectations clear

Instead of	Try
"Clean up your room."	"Put the cars in the blue bin and the books on the shelf."
"Stop running!"	"Walking feet inside, please."
"Don't throw your food."	"When you're done, say 'All done' and hand me your plate."
"Can you put your shoes on?"	"It's time to put your shoes on."
"Be nice to your brother."	"If you want his truck, ask, 'Can I have a turn when you're done?'"

Good expectations are **specific, positive** (what to do, not what to stop), **realistic** for your child's age, and stated as a **statement** when they aren't optional.

Teach it like a skill: Show, Practice, Praise

1. **Tell:** Explain the expectation in simple words and have your child say it back.
2. **Show:** Model it yourself, talking through each step.
3. **Practice:** Have your child try it while things are calm. Guide gently if needed.
4. **Praise and coach:** Give specific feedback right away. "You put your cup right in the sink. Perfect!" or "Almost! Let's try that again so the cup goes all the way in."

Practice in calm moments, not in the middle of a meltdown. Nobody learns well when they're upset.

Set the stage

- **Predictable routines** lower anxiety. Use the same order for mornings and bedtime.
- **First-then:** put the less-preferred task before the preferred one. "First pajamas, then one more book."

- **Give a heads-up** before transitions.
- **Plan the environment:** put tempting items away, keep needed items within reach.
- **Model it:** if you want calm voices, use one. Children copy what we do more than what we say.

TRY IT THIS WEEK

- [ ] Rewrite my three most-repeated instructions as clear, positive statements
- [ ] Teach one routine using Show, Practice, Praise
- [ ] Use a first-then statement at a tricky time of day

PAUSE AND REFLECT

Which expectation have I repeated many times but never actually taught?

Where could a predictable routine make our days easier?

ANCHOR 4

05 Teach a Better Way

We don't just stop a behavior. We replace it with something that meets the same need, more easily.

Why stopping isn't enough

If a child's need isn't met, the behavior returns, or a new one takes its place. A child who hits to get a toy and is only punished hasn't learned how to get a toy appropriately. Teaching the replacement is what makes change last.

Three rules for a replacement behavior

1. **Same need:** it gets the child what the old behavior got them.
2. **Easier:** it takes less effort than the problem behavior. One word beats a long polite sentence for a young child.
3. **It works, every time at first:** honor the new behavior consistently while it's being learned. You can add waiting or limits once it's strong.

Problem behavior	The need	Replacement to teach
Hitting a sibling to get their attention	Attention	Say their name or tap their shoulder
Grabbing a toy	Access	"Can I have a turn?"
Throwing food to be done	Escape	"All done"
Screaming when a task is too hard	Escape/help	"Help, please" or "This is hard"
Slamming the door to be left alone	Escape	"I need some space"
Whining for a snack	Access	"Snack, please"

Give the exact words

"Use your words" and "Ask nicely" don't tell a child *which* words. Give the exact phrase instead ("Say, 'Blue cup, please'"), then gradually wait a moment longer so they start saying it on their own.

Reduce the payoff for the old behavior

- Keep your reactions to attention-seeking behavior small: a neutral face, few words, little eye contact.
- Redirect briefly and calmly ("Feet on the floor"), then give warm attention when they're back on track.
- Don't give the item, the extra time, or the escape *because of* the problem behavior.
- Ignore the behavior, never the child: "I'm right here. I'll be ready when your voice is calm."

Practice outside the hard moment

Role-play the new skill when everyone is calm. Make it playful: act out the "not so helpful way" and the "helpful way" and let your child decide which is which.

WORKSHEET

Replacement plan

The behavior	What it gets my child	What I'll teach instead	How I'll practice	How I'll reward it

PAUSE AND REFLECT

Is the replacement I've chosen truly as easy for my child as the old behavior?

Am I still accidentally rewarding the old behavior sometimes?

ANCHOR 5

06 Follow Through Calmly

Say it once, mean it, and help it happen. Calm follow-through teaches more than repeated reminders.

Instructions that work

- Get close and get their attention first. Instructions shouted from another room are easy to miss.
- Give **one step at a time** to young children.
- Say it as a statement. Save questions for real choices.
- Put a reason first and the instruction last: "Dinner's ready, so please wash your hands."
- Use gestures: point to the shoes, the bin, the sink.
- **Praise the first step** toward following through: "You're already walking to the bathroom. Thank you!"

When they don't follow through

1. Remove what's competing for their attention (pause the show, set the toy aside).
2. Restate the instruction once, calmly.
3. Within a few seconds, help them do it with the smallest support that works: a gesture, a guiding hand, walking with them.
4. Skip the lecture. Thank them when it's done and move on.

When follow-through is consistent, children stop testing whether this is one of the times you mean it.

Hearing "no"

- If you can say yes to a calm, polite request ("Can I have five more minutes?"), say yes sometimes. It teaches that asking well works.
- When the answer is no, offer what they *can* have before any meltdown: "We can't go to the park today, but we can play with the hose in the yard."
- Give a reason once, if any. Then keep things moving.
- Teach a phrase for accepting no ("Okay" or "Maybe next time") and celebrate it when you hear it.
- If they get upset, stay calm and don't add new offers. Giving in after a meltdown teaches that meltdowns work.

Easier transitions

- Give a warning: "Five more minutes, then it's bath time."
- Pair the transition with something to look forward to, offered *before* any protest: "Time to leave the park. When we get to the car, you can pick the music."

- Teach a polite way to ask for a moment: "Can I finish this page?" Honor it when you reasonably can, then follow through.
- Avoid going straight from a favorite activity to a least favorite one; add a neutral step in between.

Real choices

Choices give children a sense of control within your limits: "Do you want to walk to the car or hop like a bunny?" "Red pajamas or blue?" Offer them before problems start, and only offer choices you're happy with.

TRY IT THIS WEEK

- [ ] Give instructions only from close by
- [ ] Praise the first step of every instruction for one day
- [ ] Use "We can't ___, but we can ___" before a predictable disappointment
- [ ] Plan something to look forward to for our hardest transition

PAUSE AND REFLECT

How many times do I usually repeat an instruction before I follow through?

Which transition is hardest in our home, and what could make it easier?

ANCHOR 6

07 Stay Steady Through Big Feelings

Big feelings aren't a problem to fix. Our calm presence is what helps a child find their way back.

Your calm is contagious

When a child is overwhelmed, their thinking brain goes offline. Matching their intensity adds fuel. A quiet voice, slow breathing, and fewer words send the message: *You're safe, and I can handle this.*

Accept the feeling, hold the limit

- Feelings are always okay. Some behaviors are not. "You're really angry that playtime is over. It's okay to be angry. I won't let you kick."
- Avoid "Calm down" or "It's not a big deal." Name what you see instead.
- Give space if your child asks for it, and stay nearby.
- Save the lesson for later. Talk about what happened once everyone is calm.
- Notice and praise the recovery: "You took some deep breaths and you're ready to try again. That was hard, and you did it."

Build a feelings vocabulary

- Name feelings throughout the day, especially positive ones: proud, excited, relieved, brave.
- Name your own feelings and how you handle them: "I'm feeling frustrated that I burned the toast. I'm going to take a breath and make another piece."
- Teach simple phrases: "I'm frustrated." "This is hard." "I need a break."
- Read stories together and wonder how the characters feel.

Choose your battles

Not every eye roll or sigh needs a response. If your child is still doing what was asked, a little attitude can pass without comment. Focus your energy on safety, respect, and follow-through, and let the small stuff go.

Repair matters

Every parent loses their cool sometimes. What matters most is coming back together. "I yelled earlier, and I'm sorry. I was frustrated, but yelling wasn't okay. Let's try again." Repair teaches children how relationships recover after conflict.

WORKSHEET

My calm-down plan

When I notice I'm getting upset...	My early signs	What helps me reset
In my body		
In my thoughts		
What I'll say out loud		

PAUSE AND REFLECT

What does my child see me do when things don't go my way?

Which of my child's feelings are hardest for me to sit with, and why?

WHEN LIMITS ARE NEEDED

08 Consequences That Teach

Consequences work best when they are planned, calm, reasonable and rare. Reinforcement does most of the teaching.

Start with the foundation

Most behavior improves through connection, clear expectations, practice and praise. When those are in place, you'll need consequences far less often.

When a consequence is needed

- **Plan it ahead**, when everyone is calm, and tell your child: "If the bike gets left in the driveway, it stays in the garage until Saturday."
- **Keep it reasonable** and short enough that you'll actually follow through.
- **Make it meaningful** to your child. Losing one toy means little to a child with many others.
- **Stay neutral** when you follow through. Let the consequence do the talking: "The bike stays in the garage until Saturday. You can try again then."
- **Practice the right behavior** so your child knows what to do next time.

Avoid these traps

Trap	Why it backfires	Try instead
Threats made in anger	Usually too big to follow through on, so they lose meaning	Decide consequences in advance
"Why did you do that?!"	Puts attention on the behavior; children rarely know why	"Next time, what could you do instead?"
Lecturing right after a child gets hurt	No one can learn while they're hurt or scared	Comfort first, talk about safety later
Taking away earned rewards	Teaches that effort doesn't count	Keep earned rewards; use a separate consequence
Yelling to stop yelling	Models the very behavior you want to stop	Lower your voice and slow down

About time-out

If you use a break away from the action, keep it short (about one minute per year of age for young children), in a calm, boring spot, and without talking during it. Use it for serious behavior like hurting others, after other tools have been tried. A break should never be a way to escape a task the child still needs to finish.

WORKSHEET

Consequence planning

Behavior I want to change	What I've taught instead	A fair consequence	How long	When I'll explain it

PAUSE AND REFLECT

Do my consequences usually happen in the heat of the moment, or are they planned?

Have I taught and practiced the behavior I'm expecting?

PUTTING IT TO WORK

09 Everyday Situations

The same anchors apply to every part of the day. Here's how they look in the moments that tend to be hardest.

Mealtimes

- Start with short, positive stretches at the table and build up gradually.
- Offer at least one food your child usually eats at each meal, and skip making a second meal.
- Look at how your child eats over a week, not one meal. Avoid pressure and bribes to take bites.
- Keep the table engaging: talk, play word games, tell stories.
- Teach "All done" so leaving the table doesn't require a meltdown.

Mornings

- Prepare the night before: clothes, backpack, lunch.
- Use a simple picture or checklist routine in the same order every day.
- Give one step at a time, and praise each step.
- Leave more time than you think you need. Rushing invites conflict.

Bedtime

- Keep the routine consistent and calm, with the least favorite steps (teeth, pajamas) before the favorite ones (stories, cuddles).
- Start early enough that no one has to rush.
- If your child gets out of bed, return them calmly with very few words. Keep it boring.
- Celebrate staying in bed in the morning.

Screens

- Set predictable screen times and agree on the amount before starting.
- Give a warning before time is up, and practice turning the screen off when calm.
- Follow screen time with something your child enjoys, and avoid screens right before bed.

Outings and errands

- Talk about the plan and the expectations before you go in.
- Give your child a job: hold the list, find items, push the cart.
- Give attention early and often, before boredom sets in.

- Bring snacks and something small to do while waiting.

Siblings

- Give it a minute before stepping in; children often work it out.
- If you do step in, stay calm and skip "who started it." Coach them through it with words they can use.
- Teach turn-taking and asking skills when everyone is calm.
- Notice and celebrate cooperation: "You two built that together!"
- Protect one-on-one time with each child.

Clean-up

- Wait to add clean-up until transitions are going smoothly.
- Be specific and realistic: "Blocks in the bin" rather than "Clean your room."
- Help, especially at first, and praise the effort.

EXTRA SUPPORT

10 Motivation Tools

For skills that are hard, new or not happening yet, a simple reward system can give your child the boost to get started.

When to use one

Everyday praise and attention are enough for most behaviors. A reward system helps when a behavior takes real effort (staying in bed, trying new foods, morning independence) or hasn't started happening yet.

Setting it up

1. **Choose one to three specific, positive behaviors.** "Stay in your bed until the light turns green," not "Be good at night."
2. **Pick a simple system** your child finds fun: tokens in a jar, stickers, stamps, or points.
3. **Create a reward menu together** with small and bigger choices: extra story time, picking dinner, a special outing, a small toy.
4. **Make early success easy.** The first rewards should come quickly.
5. **Teach it:** explain, show, and practice earning a token.
6. **Pair every token with specific praise**, so praise carries the motivation over time.

Keep it working

- Make the wait match your child's age. Younger children need rewards quickly; older children can work toward something over several days.
- Never take away tokens that have already been earned.
- Don't give tokens for "almost," and don't give in to begging.
- Refresh the reward menu every few weeks.
- Fade the system gradually once the behavior is a habit: require a bit more for each token, or give them less often.

WORKSHEET

Reward plan

Behavior I want to encourage	How it earns a token	Tokens needed	Rewards my child chose

YOUR PLAN

11 My Anchored Parenting Plan

Small, steady steps change family life. Choose one focus at a time.

WORKSHEET

Right now

My child's biggest challenge: _____

When it happens most: _____

What I usually do: _____

What it may be getting my child: _____

WORKSHEET

My plan

Anchor	What I'll do
Understand: what I think is behind it	
Connect: how I'll fill the cup	
Clarify: the expectation I'll teach	
Teach: the replacement behavior	
Follow through: what I'll do every time	
Stay steady: how I'll keep myself calm	

DAILY PRACTICE

Daily anchors

- [ ] Ten minutes of special time
- [ ] Five positives for every correction
- [ ] Name one feeling and one strength
- [ ] Model calm out loud when something goes wrong
- [ ] Repair if I lose my cool

WORKSHEET

Weekly check-in

Week of	What's getting better	What's still hard	One thing to adjust

TOOLKIT

12 Quick Reference

Words for the moments that matter most.

WORKSHEET

Words that help

When...	Try saying
Giving an instruction	"It's time to put your shoes on."
Noticing good behavior	"You shared your crayons with your sister. That was kind."
Saying no	"We can't ___ right now, but we can ___."
A transition is coming	"Five more minutes, then bath. You can bring your boat."
They're getting frustrated	"You can say, 'This is hard' or 'Help, please.'"
They want something	"Say, 'Snack, please.'"
They need a break	"You can say, 'I need space.' I'll be right here."
Big feelings	"You're really upset. I'm here. I won't let you hit."
Offering help	"Do you want help, or do you want to try on your own?"
A choice	"Do you want to walk or should I carry you?"
After a hard moment	"That was hard. What could we try next time?"
After you lose your cool	"I'm sorry I yelled. Let's try again."

KEY IDEA

Phrases to retire

- "How many times do I have to tell you?"
- "Why would you do that?"
- "Use your words." (Give the exact words instead.)
- "Calm down!"
- "Do you understand?"
- "I told you so."

WORKSHEET

When things aren't working

If you notice...	It may mean...	Try...
The same behavior keeps happening	It's still getting something	Track the ABCs and look for the payoff
Behavior gets worse at first	The old way isn't working anymore (normal)	Stay calm and consistent; it usually passes
The new skill isn't being used	It's too hard or not reliably working	Make it easier and honor it every time
Instructions are ignored	Too long, too far away, or a question	One step, up close, then help them do it
Transitions end in meltdowns	Leaving something fun is hard	Warning, something to look forward to, a buffer step
Hard days cluster together	Setting events (sleep, hunger, stress)	Lighten demands and add connection
Rewards stopped working	Wait is too long or rewards are stale	Faster wins and a refreshed menu

KEY IDEA

When to reach out for more support

If challenging behavior is frequent, intense, unsafe, or not improving with consistent effort, or if you're feeling overwhelmed, reach out. Support for children and parents is a sign of strength, not failure.

SOURCES AND FURTHER READING

This workbook is an independent resource written in original language. It draws on the principles of applied behavior analysis and positive parenting, and was informed by the online course *Practical Parenting: No Fluff, Just Results* (@ABAnaturally) and Cooper, J. O., Heron, T. E., & Heward, W. L., *Applied Behavior Analysis* (3rd ed., Pearson, 2020). Not affiliated with or endorsed by these authors.